Complexity and the Practical Human Solution

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A Law Baked Into Reality

01 Complexity is not just annoying; it is a **metaphysical law**.

02 Everything that works **starts simple**.

03 Systems grow more tangled no matter how careful you are.

04 This is the fundamental challenge of all organized structures.

The Spaghetti Graph Effect

> Clean start: A new **Obsidian vault** or project.

> Structure breaks: Add plugins, add notes, and **complexity explodes**.

> Organization trap: More time **organizing** than working.

> Ubiquitous: Passwords, email, and business systems.

```
user@lilug:~/graph$ visualize --spaghetti
[*] Initializing clean graph... [OK]
[*] Adding nodes (plugins)... [OK]
[*] Adding edges (links)... [OK]
[!] Warning: Circular dependencies detected.
[!] Warning: Cognitive load threshold exceeded.
[!] Error: Graph complexity too high for human.

( • ) ( • ) ( • )
```

The Rock Solid Theories

Gall's Law

Complex systems that work invariably evolved from simple systems that worked.

Functional Information

Systems naturally grow more complex when they are under selection for usefulness.

Tesler's Law

You can't delete complexity—you can only move it around.

Ashby's Law

Your organizing system must be at least as complex as the mess it's trying to manage.

// Reference: Systems Theory & Information Science

The Key Insight: Hard Limits

DIGITAL SPACE (AI)

Limit: **Context Window**

Constraint: Token capacity per request.

Failure: Hallucination or data loss.

[||||||||||||||||||||-----] 80% LOAD

MEAT SPACE (HUMAN)

Limit: **Energy & Time**

Constraint: Finite daily cognitive window.

Failure: Burnout or overwhelm.

[|||||||||||||||||||||||||] 100% LOAD

"The smart ones treat that daily window like a hard budget."

The Practical Human Solution

RUTHLESS DISCIPLINE

```
$ sudo rm -rf complexity/
$ mkdir -p simplicity/discipline
$ status: [REORGANIZING]
```

- # Simple **file system conventions** over complex apps.
- # No complex tagging or deep nesting.
- # High-level containers that respect **cognitive load**.
- # The goal is **clarity**, not perfection.

Top-Level Containers for Clarity

```
/ root
├──PROJECTS
├──AREAS
├──FINANCES
├──HEALTH
└──ARCHIVE
```

01 At the root level, use only **BIG, ALL-CAPS** folders.

02 These are your primary **top-level containers**.

03 Never nest deeper than **one or two layers**.

04 Structure provides immediate clarity and **reduces friction**.

The Core Five Folders

root@lilug:~# ls -F /home/user/documents/

PROJECTS/

Your active desktop. What you are working on right now.

AREAS/

All your ongoing interests and long-term responsibilities.

ARCHIVE/

Completed projects and cold storage for reference.

CALENDAR/

System for deadlines and time-sensitive reminders.

FINANCES, HEALTH, IDEAS/

Specific top-level domains for life management.

Managing Depth with Johnny Decimal

```
10-19   FINANCE
├──11   TAX
└──12   BANKING
20-29   PROJECTS
├──21   LILUG_TALK
└──22   APP_DEV
```

01 One or two layers deep—**nothing more**.

02 For deeper projects, use the **Johnny Decimal** system.

03 Number your folders so they **always sort** the same way.

04 Predictable structure means you **never lose track**.

Respect Your Brain's Limits

```yaml
# system_config.yaml
plugins: false
fancy_tags: false
extra_systems: false
clean_folders: true
human_brain_compat: true

// Status: [OPTIMIZED]
```

01 No plugins. No fancy tags. No extra systems.

02 Just **clean, consistent folders** that respect your brain.

03 Systems that respect the **human brain's** processing capacity.

04 This is how you do your own cleanup **without adding complexity**.

AI Assistance Within Boundaries

```
user@lilug:~$ ai --analyze "Refactor legacy script"
[AI] Analysis complete.
- Estimated time: 45 minutes
- Estimated cost: $4.00 (tokens)
- Next step: Decompose into 3 sub-tasks.
user@lilug:~$ ai --status
[AI] Status: Respecting context window.
[AI] Status: Aligning with human energy budget.
```

01 AI can help, but only inside these same **boundaries**.

02 It can estimate **task time and token costs**.

03 It can suggest the **"smartest next thing"** when you're stuck.

04 Only works if you keep requests small and respect **context windows**.

Call to Action: A Simple Framework

- [!] We need a **simple framework app** that brings this all together.
- [!] An app that understands **real human limits**: energy, money, time.
- [!] Uses AI to **estimate costs** and next steps without breaking discipline.
- [!] Never overloads your **daily window**.

```
FRAMEWORK V1.0

ENERGY_BUDGET: 100%
AI_CONTEXT: OPTIMIZED
FOLDER_DEPTH: 2 (MAX)
NEXT_STEP: DECOMPOSE_TASK

// Status: [READY_TO_BUILD]
```

Working With the Law

[+] Complexity is a **feature of reality**, not a bug.

[+] Respect the laws of systems (Gall, Tesler, Ashby).

[+] Build systems that acknowledge **human and AI limits**.

[+] Stop fighting it; **start mapping it**.

$ logout --questions? _